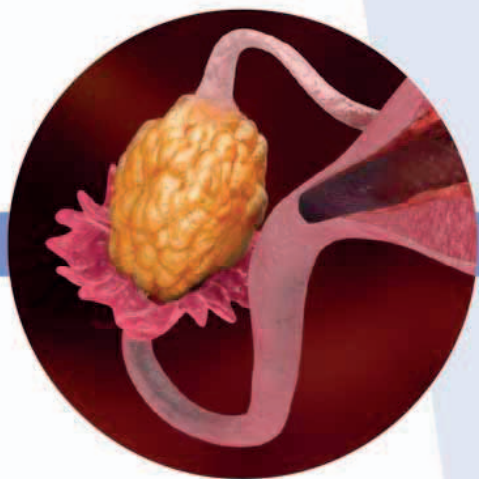


First trimester

DAYS 1–14 The countdown of your pregnancy begins with your period—the start of the fertility cycle.



Baby watch

There is no baby yet, but the ovarian follicles are working to ripen the next egg.

Mom matters

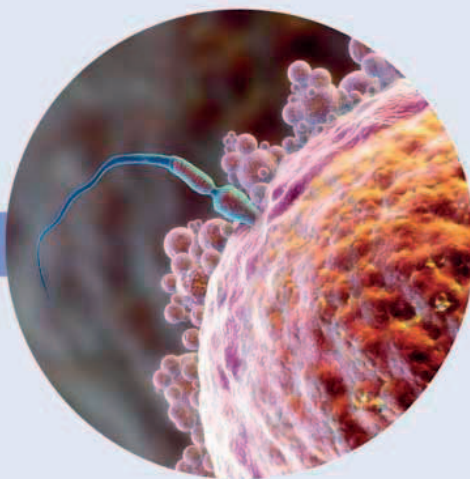
Since it is often hard to be sure of the exact date when fertilization takes place, the first day of your last menstrual period (LMP) is used as a marker. In the first two weeks the body is resetting the fertility cycle: in the first week, the previous month's uterine lining sheds; in the second week, the uterine lining has begun to thicken in preparation for the next opportunity to conceive a baby.



This week...

- » Start taking 400 mcg folic acid daily, before conception.
- » Both you and your partner should adopt a healthy lifestyle to increase your chances of becoming pregnant and having a trouble-free pregnancy—stop smoking and drinking alcohol, reduce caffeine intake, and get regular exercise.
- » It's a good idea to get your health checked by a doctor, making sure your immunizations are up to date, and seeking advice on how to get existing conditions under control.
- » Obesity can result in high-risk pregnancies, and should be tackled before you conceive. It can also interfere with your hormones and lower your chances of conceiving.

2 WEEKS A mature egg is released from the ovaries and if a sperm fertilizes it, a baby is conceived.



Baby watch

Length: approximately $\frac{1}{250}$ in (0.1 mm)

Once released, an egg can survive for up to 24 hours as it waits to be fertilized. Around 200–500 million sperm are ejaculated during orgasm, but only a few hundred will make it all the way to the egg, where one winning sperm will penetrate and fertilize it. Shortly after fertilization, the outer layer of the egg thickens so that no other sperm can enter. The sperm and egg fuse their genetic material to start making your baby, which begins life as a single cell called a zygote.

Mom matters

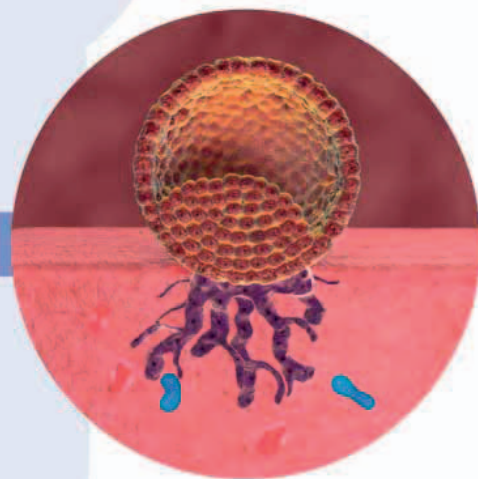
The zygote will signal its existence to the pituitary gland in your brain. A new hormone is released called human chorionic gonadotrophin (hCG) that overrides your usual monthly cycle.



This week...

- » Enjoy sex frequently to give yourselves the best chance of conceiving. Have sex at least every two to three days throughout the month.
- » Make sure you find time to relax and unwind—stress may affect your ability to become pregnant. It's no wonder that many couples seem to conceive while on vacation.

3 WEEKS Amazing things are happening inside your body, and some women may experience early signs.



Baby watch

Length: $> \frac{1}{32}$ in (1 mm)

Your baby-to-be is now a ball of around 100 cells called a blastocyst. It burrows into the lining of the uterus, which has become sticky to help it attach securely. The place where it implants will eventually develop into a placenta; for now a yolk sac is forming to nourish your baby in the earliest stages.

Mom matters

Hormones, including estrogen and progesterone, surge through your body to help the blastocyst settle safely. It's possible to experience very early symptoms such as sore breasts and fatigue. When the egg implants, it can cause some slight bleeding or "spotting," but this bleeding should be light, brief, and not painful.



This week...

- » While you are waiting to find out whether you are pregnant, avoid alcohol, smoking, and caffeine and eat a balanced diet. This will give your baby a great start.
- » You may be able to find out whether you are pregnant this week using an extra-sensitive pregnancy test.
- » Consult your doctor about whether or not it is safe to continue taking any existing medication.